

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

UTTAR PRADESH
Rahul Modalwal, 27, *Diploma in optometry*

Job applied for: Optometrist in government hospital
Total vacancies: 46; Total applications: 525

A resident of Sirathu, a non-descript town in UP's Kaushambi district, Rahul appeared for the 10+2 board examination (science stream) in 2012 and followed it up with a two-year diploma course in optometry from a private institute in nearby Prayagraj. He found employment as an optometrist in several private hospitals, but at a miserly salary of Rs 5,000 a month. Desperate, Rahul was always on the lookout for a government job. So, when the state health department started the process of recruiting optometrists for 46 posts, Rahul wasted no time applying for it. Unfortunately, he was not selected. And the government has not recruited any optometrist since. Staring at a bleak future, Rahul shifted back to his home town and began working at his father's sweet shop. "I wasted a lot of time waiting for recruitment of optometrists in government hospitals. There is no job in the government sector, while salaries in the private sector are very low," says Rahul.

Sarma is targeting by May 10—his electoral promise last year—around 52,000 are for police, health and education. It includes creation of 5,000 additional posts in the police department. "There will be no vacancy in these three departments," he promises.

Why are governments not hiring?

Most officials are chary of coming on record, but concede that the cost-cutting imperative is driving a general trend towards contractual employment. "There has been an unofficial directive to keep departments lean," a secretary in a Union ministry tells INDIA TODAY. So, whenever a person retires, contractual employees come in, often designated as consultants. Several ministries have found this convenient, as it also allows them to bypass the regular process—with its attendant demands on time and money. The advocates of this short-cut arrangement claim this not only makes hiring easier, but also improves efficiency. "Driven by the principle of perform or perish, contractual appointments can be highly competitive and productive," says an IAS officer from Bengal. 'Productive' can have other meanings too in India: skirting the regular process often happens at the behest of politicians. Hiring of temporary workers, and their eventual regularisation, creates a route to accommodate private recommendations. Besides, all this is much cheaper. Being able to drop the perks isn't the only cost-saving feature here. Even the process of holding exams incurs huge expenses. "Recruiting 100,000 will cost my government around Rs 200 crore. I'll have to reduce capital and revenue expenditure immediately for that, though the added manpower will benefit the state in the long run," says Assam chief minister Sarma.

Government jobs have also shrunk because of technological progress, of course. For instance, the internet and smartphones have killed off letter writing—except in the realm of official communication. That has reduced the need for manpower in the postal department. Practices borrowed from the private sector have also decluttered bureaucratic functioning, reducing dependency on human intervention. Besides the efficiency curve, not much of its implication on jobs is officially stated, or tabulated—the unrealistic nature of public expectations, meanwhile, is sustained via promises. The dream of a 'government job' is alive and kicking.

Pradip Kumar Tripathi, secretary, DoPT, the nodal ministry for central jobs, says his ministry only facilitates the hiring process. "It's the prerogative